

STUDENTS' DIFFICULTIES IN WRITING PROCEDURE TEXT: A CASE STUDY AT SMA ASSANADIYAH PALEMBANG

Dini Lorenza¹, Hj. Renny Kurniasari, M.Pd², Winny Agustia Riznanda, M.Pd³

^{1,2,3}Universitas Islam Negeri Raden Fatah Palembang

¹lorenzadini24@gmail.com, ²rennykurniasari_uin@radenfatah.ac.id

³winnyagustiariznanda_uin@radenfatah.ac.id

ABSTRACT: The purpose of this study was to determine the encountered that SMA Assanadiyah Palembang students faced when creating procedure text. A case study was used as the research design in this qualitative investigation. Six students were selected by a deliberate sampling procedure to participate in this study. Data was gathered through interviews, and theme analysis was used to examine the interview data. According to the findings, students encountered four difficulties when writing procedure text: (1) a lack of vocabulary mastery; (2) a lack of comprehension of grammar; (3) a lack of understanding of generic structure; and (4) a lack of understanding of language features

Keywords: *difficulty, procedure text, writing*

KESULITAN SISWA DALAM MENULIS TEKS PROSEDUR: STUDI KASUS DI SMA ASSANADIYAH PALEMBANG

yang dihadapi siswa SMA Assanadiyah Palembang ketika menulis teks prosedur. Studi kasus digunakan sebagai desain penelitian dalam investigasi kualitatif ini. Enam siswa dipilih melalui prosedur pengambilan sampel yang disengaja untuk berpartisipasi dalam penelitian ini. Data dikumpulkan melalui wawancara, dan analisis tema digunakan untuk memeriksa data wawancara. Menurut temuan, siswa menghadapi empat kesulitan ketika menulis teks prosedur: (1) kurangnya penguasaan kosakata; (2) kurangnya pemahaman tata bahasa; (3) kurangnya pemahaman struktur generik; dan (4) kurangnya pemahaman fitur bahasa.

Kata Kunci: *kesulitan, teks prosedur, menulis*

INTRODUCTION

In today's interconnected world, English functions as a universal language, facilitating cross-cultural communication and transcending geographical boundaries (Wahyuni et al., 2018). This has led to widespread recognition of English as an essential skill. According to Ilyosovna (2020), there are six primary reasons for learning English: its global use, its role as the language of academia, access to extensive resources, its practicality in travel, its importance in international business, and its presence in global media such as Hollywood. As a crucial part of learning English, writing is a vital skill that supports language acquisition and personal expression (Astuti et al., 2020). The ability to express oneself through writing enhances academic performance and allows for effective communication, even for those who may find verbal expression challenging (Harmoonni et al., 2018). Additionally, writing requires diverse knowledge, concepts, and experiences (Kusumaningsih et al., 2013).

Despite its importance, writing remains one of the most complex and challenging skills to develop, especially in a second language. Students must generate coherent written texts that require not only grammatical and theoretical knowledge but also judgmental and intellectual skills (Siregar & Dongoran, 2020; Sakkir, 2020; Anjani, 2020). Writing skills involve understanding mechanics, vocabulary, syntax, and content organization (Fadhilawati et al., 2020). This complexity often makes writing an intricate and non-intuitive skill to master (Cenrikawaty et al., 2020).

In Indonesia's high school curriculum, procedure texts, which outline sequential processes, are a core component of the writing syllabus. Students are expected to compose procedure texts, an exercise that enhances their ability to communicate instructions clearly (Afandi, 2020; Ameliah et al., 2019). However, research indicates that students face numerous challenges in writing procedure texts, including difficulties with proper vocabulary, grammar, and textual structure (Yahya, 2019; Annida, 2018). These difficulties are exacerbated by students' frequent use of their mother tongue, which can limit their English expression.

Preliminary observations conducted through interviews with an English teacher at SMA Assanadiyah Palembang revealed that writing procedure texts is particularly challenging for students with limited vocabulary, leading to confusion and a lack of linguistic variety (S, personal communication, October 25, 2023). Data from the 2022/2023 academic year indicated that 33% of students scored below the minimum competency criteria in their procedure text assessments. This underscores the need to investigate the challenges students face in writing procedure texts and to develop strategies to address these issues.

Research on this topic has focused largely on language features and text structure, with studies identifying vocabulary, grammar, and motivation as primary obstacles (Hidayah et al., 2021; Zai, 2023; Suryanto et al., 2020; Dewi et al., 2023; Malau et al., 2023). However, the urgency for further research lies in the need to explore a more comprehensive range of difficulties in procedure text writing, including sequence connections, adverbs, and action verbs. This research aims to provide an in-depth analysis of the multifaceted challenges students encounter in writing procedure texts, thus contributing to improved instructional strategies in teaching English writing. The objective is to examine these challenges thoroughly, with implications for enhancing students' writing proficiency in line with academic standards.

This study seeks to address the following objectives: to identify specific difficulties students face when writing procedure texts, to assess the impact of vocabulary limitations, grammar issues, and structure comprehension on students' writing performance, and to develop targeted instructional interventions that can enhance students' writing abilities, particularly in producing coherent procedure text.

The significance of this research lies in its potential to offer valuable insights for educators and curriculum developers, enabling them to implement effective strategies that address students' procedure writing challenges.

METHODOLOGY

1 Research Method and Design

This study employed a qualitative research approach, specifically a case study design, to explore the difficulties encountered by students in writing procedure texts. Creswell (2018) describes qualitative research as a means to analyze and comprehend the meanings assigned by individuals or groups to a social issue. The case study method enables in-depth exploration of a specific situation or issue—here, the challenges faced by students in writing. Through interviews and thematic analysis, the researcher sought to identify the underlying causes of students' difficulties.

2 Research Setting and Date

The study was conducted at SMA Assanadiyah Palembang during the odd semester of the 2021/2022 academic year. Data collection and analysis spanned from October 25th, 2023, to November 30th, 2023.

3 Participants and Sampling Technique

Participants in this study were selected through purposeful sampling, as recommended by Patton (2014), to allow for comprehensive understanding of specific cases. Six tenth-grade students from SMA Assanadiyah Palembang were chosen as participants, based on their performance on procedure text writing assessments. These students scored below the minimum competency criteria (KKM) of 65, indicating potential difficulties in writing procedure texts.

4 Techniques in Collecting Data

4.1 Interviews

Data collection for this study relied exclusively on interviews. Following Creswell's (2018) recommendations, semi-structured, open-ended questions were used to allow for flexibility and detailed responses from participants (DeJonckheere & Vaughn, 2019). The interviews focused on specific aspects of procedure text writing, such as vocabulary, grammar, generic structure, and language features, as highlighted by Hidayah et al. (2021), Zai (2023), and Suryanto et al. (2019). Interviews were conducted individually, face-to-face, outside the classroom, and were recorded to ensure data accuracy.

4.2 Interview Procedures

The interview process included several phases:

1. The researcher prepared a recording device and established rapport with each participant.

2. The participants provided demographic information, followed by open-ended questions regarding their challenges in writing procedure texts.
3. Each interview concluded with a summary of the participant's responses and expressions of gratitude.

5 Data Analysis

Thematic analysis, as outlined by Nowell et al. (2017), was used to analyze the data. Data analysis was conducted in several stages:

1. Data Preparation: This involved transcribing interviews, organizing data, and categorizing information from various sources.
2. Reading and Familiarization: The researcher reviewed all data to gain a comprehensive understanding of the material.
3. Coding: Each interview transcript was coded based on recurring words, phrases, and themes using participants' own language.
4. Theme Development: Coded data were organized into themes representing major challenges and perceptions related to writing procedure texts.
5. Narrative Presentation: The analysis was presented as a narrative summary to communicate the findings and interpretation of the data.

6 Establishment of Trustworthiness

To ensure the accuracy of the findings, member-checking was employed, a process in which participants review the data for verification (Varpio et al., 2017). Participants reviewed transcripts shortly after each interview to confirm the accuracy of their responses, reducing potential biases (Candela, 2019). This step involved participant feedback on whether the findings were realistic and comprehensive, as recommended by Birt et al. (2016).

FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

FINDINGS

After analyzing the interview data, the researcher tried to answer the research problem related to the difficulties faced by tenth grade students at Assanadiyah Palembang High School when writing procedure text. Six students, namely D, FM, MIW, ZA, RA, and MR, were chosen as participants based on the results of the students' in writing procedure text which indicates that they experienced difficulty in composing procedure text. There are some themes and codes listed from the analysis of qualitative data that are shown in Table below:

Themes and codes for students' difficulties in writing procedure text at SMA Assanadiyah Palembang

Themes	Codes
Lack of vocabulary mastery in writing procedure text	a. The students said that they encountered difficulty in writing procedure text due to their limited vocabulary. b. Some vocabularies were unfamiliar for the students.
Lack of understanding of	a. The students perceived that they were confused

tenses used in writing a procedure text	which tense is appropriate for writing a procedure text.
Lack of comprehension towards generic structure in writing procedure text	a. The students perceived that they encountered difficulty in determining a title that is easy to work on and not the same with their classmates. b. The students encountered difficulty in determining the materials or tools, especially if the title was chosen by the teacher. c. The students said that they had difficulty in sequencing the steps correctly because some of the steps were similar and long enough for them.
Lack of comprehension towards language features in writing procedure text	a. The students said that they were often confused in choosing the correct temporal conjunctions and often forgot to add them. b. The students said that they were confused on the use of action verbs. c. The students said that they were confused in differentiating between the use of action verbs and adverbs.

1. Lack of Vocabulary Mastery in Writing Procedure Text

Based on the data obtained from interviews, it was found some problems encountered by students at SMA Assanadiyah Palembang, one of which was that the students lack of vocabulary. Students limited vocabulary made it difficult for the students to choose the right words for writing procedure text. It is supported by student FM who stated that *“I did not memorize all the vocabulary clearly”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Similarly, student RA also stated that *“I’m not comfortable, because I did not memorize too many vocabulary in English, I only memorize a few”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). It can be concluded stated that some students lack vocabulary when writing procedure text, students have difficulty with vocabulary because they do not memorize a lot of it and were still confused about how to write them correctly.

Based on the data obtained from interviews, it was found that one of the problems that the students encountered were confused by unfamiliar vocabulary, made it difficult for students to find the right words to write procedure text. It is supported by student MIW stated that *“Especially if the vocabulary is unfamiliar”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Another statement by student MR stated that *“It is difficult, if I have to translate one by one because then the grammar will be wrong”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). It can be concluded that students are still often confused when they encounter vocabulary that they think is unfamiliar when writing procedure text.

2. Lack of grammar understanding in writing procedure text

Based on the data obtained from the interview, it was found that one of the problems faced by students at SMA Assanadiyah Palembang was the lack of grammar. The lack of students' understanding of simple present tense makes it difficult for students to create the right tenses when writing procedure text. It is supported by student MIW stated that *"Sometimes I get confused in distinguishing between simple present tense and simple continuous tense because they are both present tense"* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Supported by student MR stated that *"I often find it difficult because sometimes I am confused about which tense to use when writing procedure text"* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Another statement by student ZA stated that *"I often have difficulty because there are too many tenses in English, so I often forget"* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Supported by student FM stated by *"I often find it difficult, because sometimes I am confused about which tense to use when writing procedure text"* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). It can be concluded that students have confused which tense is appropriate for writing a procedure text, students have difficulty using simple present tense due to a lack of knowledge about the correct use of simple present tense when writing procedure text.

3. Lack of comprehension towards generic structure in writing procedure text

Based on the data obtained from the interview results, it was found some problems encountered by students at SMA Assanadiyah Palembang, one of which was that the students' were confused about difficulty in determining the title. It is supported by student D stated that *"Yes, because if I use an easy title, it will be the same as my classmates"* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Another statement by student FM stated that *"I have a bit of difficulty determining the title of the procedure text because I'm not sure if my title is easy enough to work on"* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). It can be concluded that students often feel confused in determining the title of the procedure text and lack confidence in doing it.

Based on the data obtained from the interview result, it was found that one of the problems that the students encountered were confused about difficulty in determining the materials or tools. It is supported by student MIW stated that *"I even have problems identifying the materials and tools in Bahasa. Let alone the terms in English, but it also depends on the title"* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Another statement by students D stated that *"If I make the title myself, I can find the materials, unless the title is determined by the teacher"* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Another statement by students FM and MR stated that *"I have difficulty finding materials and tools that match the title of my procedure text because I do not know what tools match my title"* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). It can be concluded that the students feel confused when determining materials or tools that were appropriate to the title that students had determined.

Based on the data obtained from the interview results, it was found that one of the problems that the students encountered were confused about students expressed difficulty in arranging the steps sequentially. It is supported by student MR stated that *"Sometimes I'm confused if there are steps that can be done simultaneously or are"*

somewhat similar” (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Furthermore, supported by students MIW, D, and ZA stated that *“In my opinion, if the steps are long”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). It can be concluded that the students often feel confused if there are too many steps, and often find it difficult to arrange the steps correctly.

4. Lack of comprehension towards language features in writing procedure text

Based on the data obtained from the interview results, it was found some problems encountered by students at SMA Assanadiyah Palembang, one of the which was that the students’ difficulty in determining temporal conjunctions when writing procedure text. It is supported by students D stated that *“Sometimes I find it difficult to choose the right temporal conjunction for each step, and sometimes I forget to add it”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Another statement by MIW stated that *“I often get confused about choosing the right word or feel unsure whether the word I choose is correct or clear”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). Another statement by student MR stated that *“In my opinion, the words next, then, and after that make me confused about which one should come first”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). It can be concluded that the students have difficulty using language features because students do not know what temporal conjunctions are when writing steps in procedure text.

Based on the data obtained from the interview results, it was found that one of the problems that the students encountered were difficulty in understanding action verbs when writing procedure text. It is supported by student ZA stated that *“In my opinion, is ensuring that the action verb is correct or not. Sometimes there are also vocabularies that I do not know, so I’m confused about how to write them”*. Similarity by student RA stated that *“The most difficult thing is the action verbs, because it has to match the title, especially if the title is complicated”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). It can be concluded that the students experienced difficulty using language features in writing procedure text when using action verbs because of their lack of understanding of action verbs.

Based on the data obtained from the interview results, it was found that one of the problems that the students encountered were difficulty in distinguish action verbs and adverbs when writing procedure text. It is supported by students MR, FM, and MIW stated that *“I always have difficulty differentiating between adverbs and action verbs because I think the two are quite similar”* (Personal Interview, July 31th 2024). It can be concluded that the students had difficulties in using language features in writing procedure text when distinguishing action verbs and adverbs because they thought they were almost the same.

DISCUSSION

This discussion of findings aims to explore students' challenges in writing procedure texts, supported by prior research and data analysis. First, a significant issue is students’ limited vocabulary, which affects their word choice and increases reliance on translation tools, reducing confidence. Studies by Hidayah et al. (2021) and Suryanto

et al. (2020) support this, showing that limited vocabulary hinders expression and translation abilities, making writing procedure texts more difficult.

Second, grammar issues, particularly with the simple present tense, lead to uncertainty and difficulty in sentence construction. Research by Bocayantumuscontorn (2017) and Zai (2023) highlights grammar as a primary challenge, demonstrating that students often struggle to construct sentences in the correct tense.

Third, students lack understanding of generic structure, leading to confusion when choosing titles, listing tools, and ordering steps logically. Malau et al. (2023) and Sari (2016) found similar issues with structuring and sequencing, revealing difficulties in crafting clear objectives and maintaining logical flow.

Lastly, students struggle with temporal conjunctions and distinguishing action verbs from adverbs, resulting in repetitive and disjointed writing. Research by Dewi (2023) and Malau et al. (2023) confirms that incorrect use of linguistic features, such as repetitive verbs and misused conjunctions, impacts clarity in procedure texts. In summary, students face difficulty in vocabulary, grammar, generic structure, and language features, which together complicate their ability to write effective procedure texts.

CONCLUSION

Based on the research results that the researcher analyzed using thematic analysis, it was found that the difficulty of students learning to write procedure text is in terms of a lack of understanding vocabulary. In addition, students also experience difficulties in their lack of understanding of the use of grammar, more precisely in the use of simple past tense. Not only that, students have difficulty understanding generic structures, namely difficulty in determining the title, materials, or tools, and confusion in compiling the correct steps in writing procedure text. The last difficulty in the aspect of grammar is having difficulty ordering temporal conjunctions correctly and students' lack of understanding of the use of action verbs and adverbs. So, each student has their own difficulties. This means that writing procedure text is not an easy thing; therefore, teachers must first provide basic lessons, such as teaching them a lot of vocabulary, and teachers must also master the material so that students understand and are not confused when explained by the teacher.

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